



Statement of Teaching Philosophy — Seth M. Smith

My teaching philosophy is grounded in the belief that students learn economics most effectively when they are active participants in the process of discovery rather than passive recipients of information. I view teaching as a collaborative exploration where students use economic reasoning to connect theory with the world around them and, in the process, learn to think critically about evidence and policy.

When I taught *Principles of Microeconomics* at the University of Georgia, I designed my course around interaction and engagement. Each class included active learning components such as iClicker polling, live discussion, and problem-solving exercises that invited students to test their understanding in real time. These activities transformed lectures into shared conversations that helped students see how the tools of economics apply to their everyday experiences and decisions.

Active learning also extended beyond the classroom. In a semester-long writing project, students analyzed real-world data or media pieces through the lens of economic concepts. This assignment encouraged them to bring their own interests and observations into the classroom, bridging personal experience and economic analysis. To reinforce this connection, I frequently incorporated examples and questions inspired by student contributions into exams and discussions. These moments affirmed for students that their perspectives were not only valued but integral to the learning process.

Diversity, in my view, is not something added to the classroom; it is something revealed through the process of discovery. By creating space for students to share their varied perspectives, backgrounds, and examples, I aim to cultivate an environment where economic reasoning becomes a tool for understanding multiple viewpoints. This inclusive exchange of ideas allows students to see how different life experiences shape economic choices and enrich our collective understanding of markets and policy.

Receiving the **Swift Undergraduate Teaching Fellowship** reinforced my commitment to this student-centered and inclusive approach. The recognition reflected my efforts to make economics accessible, interactive, and relevant for all students, regardless of their prior preparation or familiarity with the discipline.

Ultimately, my goal as an instructor is to help students think like economists, to ask sharp questions, analyze trade-offs, and communicate their reasoning with confidence. I want them to leave my class not just with a grasp of models and theory, but with the curiosity and intellectual flexibility to apply those tools to the diverse realities they encounter beyond the classroom.